

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

Life from Death ~ Humanity, Sin, and Morality
Eastertide 2

May 4th, 2025



Aurora Volando, 1933 - Gerardo Dottori

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
Telephone 213.385.1341 – www.FCCLA.org

The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in- Residence*

A Star Wars Organ Suite (Composed by John Williams, adapted for Organ by Christoph Bull)

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Michael Lehman

Words of Gathering

Rev. Lehman, Betsy Sullenger & Chambers Stevens

We gather now,
harvesters of an all-pervasive grace,
unexpected benefactors of the deed
to this great and glorious cosmic inheritance.

We, the walking, waking stars, ablaze with
wonder, imagination, and hope,
gather to remember three words:
kinship, with all that is;
debt, that can only be paid forward;
gift, sacred mantra of the humble.

Creation,
the great and glorious sacrifice of abundance,
asks in return – only –
that we shed our entitled egos
and drop to our knees,
uttering a single, simple prayer
that changes everything:
'Thank you....' [bs/lvf]

Please stand in body or in spirit for our Hymn of Gathering

***Hymn of Gathering**

God, Who Stretched the Spangled Heavens

HYFRYDOL

God, who stretched the spangled heavens infinite in time and place,
Flung the suns in burning radiance through the silent fields of space;
We, your children, in your likeness, share inventive powers with you;
Great Creator, still creating, show us what we yet may do.

We have ventured worlds undreamed of since the childhood of our race;
Known the ecstasy of winging through untraveled realms of space;
Probed the secrets of the atom, yielding unimagined power,
Facing us with life's destruction or our most triumphant hour.

As each far horizon beckons, may it challenge us anew,
Children of creative purpose serving others, honoring you.

May our dreams prove rich with promise, each endeavor, well begun;
Great creator, give us guidance till our goals and yours are one.

***Prayer of Awareness**

Rev. Chad Tanaka Pack

Holy One, we pause and listen to the sound of silence in this place...

We remember creation's beauty
the searing of shooting stars,
the colors of the planets in the night sky,
the space and power beyond our perceiving.

With these memories, we are moved to prayer –
to praise the mystery of the universe,
to be grateful for the mystery of our life in this place.

Be with us in this time, O God,
and help us to open our hearts and minds and bodies
to the mystery and grace, of your unending glorious presence.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!
Amen and Amen.

***Introit**

"Quia in hoc ipsum excitavi"
Cathedral Choir, Dr. Fahad Siadat, Assistant Director

SAGINAW J. ROZZO

"I raised you up for this very purpose, that I might display power through you." ~Romans 9:17

***The Lord's Prayer**

Chambers Stevens

*Holy One, beyond all names,
Eternal Wellspring,
May love rise again in us today
with food for every table,
shelter for every family,
and reverence for every life.
Forgive us our failings in love
and free us from all falseness,
that the light of our souls may shine,
and the strength of our spirits endure
for Earth and all its people
This day, tonight, and forever.
Amen and Amen!*

[John Philip Newell]

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Tanaka Pack

Eternal One, when you have drawn your cloak of night about you,
and when you have rolled back the dark sky and pinned it to the horizon,
and when you have given yourself to the light,
and when you have blurred the familiar shapes
into uncertain shadows,

then...

thou tender of day
and of night,
do not forget us.

[adapt/jrichardson]

This morning may the Peace of the Force be with you!
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow.

Please be seated

Readings from the Wisdom of Our Tradition

Betsy Sullenger & Chambers Stevens

A Reading from the Psalms...

The heavens herald your glory, O God,
and the skies display your handiwork.
Day after day they tell their story,
and night after night they reveal
the depth of their understanding.
Without speech, without words,
without even an audible voice,
their cry echoes through all the world,
and their message reaches the ends of the earth.

A Reading from the Prayer of Azariah...

Blessed are you in the high heavens, O God.
Let the sun and moon praise you.
Let the stars and all that shines with glory praise you.
For you are the God of all creation.

A Reading from Paul's Letter to the Romans...

What happens is that I don't do the good I intend to do, but the evil I do not intend.

For these words of the ancients whose wisdom we welcome in our present,
Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Rev. Tanaka Pack

In the light and beauty of this day,
we give thanks in awe and wonder.
In the dark and stillness of night
we dream of healing and hope.

In all our joys and all our concerns, may we be ever mindful
of the presentness of the sacred among us,
and may we see the possibilities of the here and now,
as we are in silence, together.

Silence

*After the silence, you are invited to come forward to bring your written prayers and to
light candles to signify the prayers of your hearts and pray for the life of the world.*

Prayers of Our Hearts

We acknowledge
a Power, a Presence
within us
within all people,
a creative, energizing Presence,
Divine,
bonding everything that exists
through patterns of attraction and co-operation,
in endless movement
toward new possibilities,
creating an inter-relational universe
that makes human life possible.

*Conscious of this Divine presence
within and among us,
we open ourselves to new possibilities.*

We expand our minds,
we embrace change,
we take risks,
we discard what no longer gives meaning to life,
we deepen our awareness and appreciation
of this Presence
emerging in us.

*We give thanks for the wonderful human gift
of conscious awareness.*

We give thanks, that in us,
the universe has found a way to reflect upon itself,
to sing, to dance,
to celebrate the joy of sound and movement,
to consciously love,
to be enthralled by the creation of new life
and new possibilities.

We open ourselves to the challenge
of fully co-operating with the energizing, creative,
Divine Presence in our own personal development,
in our relationships with all other people
and in our connectedness with and care for planet Earth.

*To all that is,
and to all that could be
through the power of the Presence
within all things,
we say, Amen.*

[mmoorwood]

Meditation Anthem

"Padme's Lament"

JOHN WILLIAMS

Cathedral Choir, Dr. Fahad Siadat, *Assistant Director*

"O Sweet Sleep. Rest, subduing fear. Sweet Sleep"

Sermon

Humanity, Sin, and Morality

Rev. Lehman

Invitation to Generosity

Rev. Tanaka Pack

We give thanks that today, in this time and place,
the God of the Universe
the Driving Force
at work in our world,
has helped us to understand
the the love that is breathed into us
becomes visible
in extravagant generosity...
and the celebration of being.

Together, we rejoice in the awareness
that we are co-creators with God
for this life
and we pray for the grace
to accept its responsibilities.

So we ask the Spirit of Life
that moves in and through the universe,
to help us in these days, to give breath
to the Divine's dream
for our lives, and for our world.

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how it's given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also be available at the exits when the service ends with baskets to collect gifts.

Offertory

"Duel of the Fates"

JOHN WILLIAMS

Cathedral Choir, Dr. Fahad Siadat, *Assistant Director*

"Under the tongue root, a fight most dread, and another raging behind, in the head."

***Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!

Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!

[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

***Prayer of Offering**

Betsy Sullenger

Eternal God, we pray aware that you,
who are at work
in the vastness of this universe
for billions of years,
will now come to visible
and audible expression
in and through these offerings.

With appreciation in our hearts,
we rejoice, O God,
that you breath life and vitality
into our world,
into our lives,
and into our gathering here,
connecting us on the deepest level
with all that exists.

*For this and so much more,
we offer our thanks on this day.
Amen and Amen.*

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Lehman

Words of Blessing

Rev. Lehman

May the Great Mystery that we call God
keep alive in each one of us
the search for a faith that is real;
a faith that helps us to lead genuine lives
a faith that gives us a fuller
meaning to life and the events of life;

*Bring us to know the goodness that flows
from the heart of the universe,
and may we be expanded in heart
and mind and body,
by that goodness.*

This is our prayer...

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Choral Response

“There’s A World”
Cathedral Choir, Dr. Fahad Siadat, *Assistant Director*

BRIAN YORKEY AND TOM KITT

*Hymn for the Journey

God, You Spin the Whirling Planets

NETTLETON

God You spin the whirling planets, fill the seas and spread the plain,
Mold the mountains, fashion blossoms, call forth sunshine, wind and rain.
We, created in Your image, would a true reflection be
Of Your justice, grace and mercy, and the truth that makes us free.

You have called us to be faithful in our life and ministry.
We respond in grateful worship joined in one community.
When we blur Your gracious image, focus us and make us whole,
Healed and strengthened as Your people, we move onward toward Your goal.

God, Your will is still creating, calling us to life made new,
Now reveal to us fresh vistas where there’s work to dare to do.
Keep us clear of all distortion, fashion us with loving care,
Thus new creatures in Your image, we’ll proclaim Christ everywhere.

Please be seated for the Postlude

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*
Star Wars Main Theme - Reprise (John Williams, arr. C. Bull)

Inside The Music

“I’m thrilled that we have the opportunity to premiere another piece by one of our members. Saginaw Rozzo has been singing with us for the last year, and has become an important part of our team. You’ve heard Dr. Bull play several of his organ pieces, and this is the first time the choir has gotten to sing his music. The text for “Quia in hoc ipsum excitavi” comes from the book of Romans, and speaks of the power of God rising up through us at important times. Saginaw’s music begins in the low voices and slowly, deliberately, rises upward. Led by the top tenor voice, the low voices churn and murmur, but move ever upward. They then pass the melody to the upper voices, who likewise progress deliberately upward before being joined again by the lower voices. They end together with a definitive E major cadence, enveloping the building energy in one changed moment. This E major stands out for several reasons. The harmony throughout the piece thus far has been on C# minor with some motion to and from A major. E major, the parallel of C# minor, doesn’t appear until this final moment. Further, the lowest note in the chord is a G#, the third of E major and the 5th of C# minor. It is a common linkage between the chords. That it roots the E major chord both connects it to the murmuring, churning C# minor, and gives the E major momentum into the silence that follows. The final chord represents a change, and one that will continue to seek its voice now that it is changed. The understanding of power flowing through us that this verse and musical setting represent feels very aligned with Star Wars philosophy. We are all subject to the flow of life energy, and are encompassed by the fullness of life’s struggles and celebrations. “Padme’s Lament” occurs in the third film during the birth of Luke and Leah. The struggle between Anakin and Padme, their love for one another and separation over whether to pursue a light or dark path, comes to a transition. Padme lays dying as their children are birthed, unknown by Anakin. The torment of their life choices churns even as sweet sleep comes over in that moment. In the broader context, it is a passing of life and hope, and a culmination of so many moments before. “Duel of the Fates” occurs during the epic Jedi battle scene at the end of the first movie. The Sanskrit words speak of a battle being waged in the physical present, and another one in the mind. We also celebrate the start of Mental Health Awareness Month with “There’s A World.” It comes from the

musical “Next To Normal,” which explores mental health. In moments like “There’s A World,” the musical reminds us that we all have the opportunity to nurture our mental health. We can daily revitalize ourselves by caring for our minds, feeding our selves, our communities, and our world.” -Dr. David Harris

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